in arming Afghan rebels in order to subvert Afghan politics. Pakistan had already moved seven army divisions to the Afghan border by mid-January 1980.[15] According to media reports, about 900 Chinese agents had also infiltrated Afghanistan near the 85-km-long border in Wakhan to arm and support the Maoist *Shola-e-Javed* group for fighting the Soviets.[16] Such activities, supplemented by America's active supply of 'arms to small and medium sized countries, and dividing the non-aligned countries' were seen as a threat by Indian policymakers.[17] The U-turn sent a shock wave both within and outside India. In one stroke, Gandhi had alienated substantial parts of the world, including many Afghans, as well as Indians.

Secondly, to contain the damage of her somersault, Gandhi made a public statement calling the Soviet invasion 'inadmissible'.[18] Even privately, she shifted gears with the Soviet foreign minister Andrei Gromyko on 12 February 1980. 'We don't approve of the presence of Soviet troops in Afghanistan though we have viewed it in historical perspective. This new situation has brought the Cold War very close to our area', she informed a baffled Gromyko.[19] She allegedly passed a similar message to Brezhnev in a state visit to Moscow, two years later in September 1982, and curtly told him (when asked by the Soviet general secretary) that the 'way out' of Afghanistan was the 'same as the way in' (much to the confusion of Brezhnev and then Indian foreign secretary M K Rasgotra, who witnessed the exchange).[20] There was hardly any meeting ground between Moscow and New Delhi on Afghanistan. The Indian media, reflecting the popular mood in New Delhi, reported 'a wide gap' between the Indian and the Soviet stand on Afghanistan in its editorial on 15 February 1980.[21] More than the intervention itself, Gandhi's problem was with the fact that it happened in India's neighbourhood. Having refrained from criticising the Soviet role in the 1956 Hungarian crisis and the 1968 Soviet invasion of Czechoslovakia, India was a trusted ally whose support was deemed important in Moscow. In May 1980, Sathe visited Kabul to probe the Afghan leadership's willingness for a political solution and found a regime eager to resolve the dispute and hold talks with Iran and Pakistan (even though their public utterances were markedly different).[22]

In June 1980, however, EAM Narasimha Rao conveyed Gandhi's unhappiness to Brezhnev during his visit to Moscow (India, by now, realised that Zia-ul-Haq